

Notes on Reading and Thinking for Students of Sociological Theory

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Preamble:

Not all thought is free association. Sometimes we must follow a rigorous argument. But few of us think naturally in rigorous arguments. Reading forces us to do that, to focus on a single argument, a single topic, a single set of data, a single universe of meanings, a single author. So we must talk about the different kinds of reading.

Section One – Thinking

Before that, however, we must talk about thinking. John Dewey - arguably the most important and influential single scholar ever employed at the University of Chicago - once said the following:

No thought, no idea can possibly be communicated as an idea from one person to another. When it is told, it is, to the one to whom it is told, another given fact, not an idea. The communication may stimulate the other person to realize the question for himself and think out a like idea, or it may smother his intellectual interest and suppress his dawning effort at thought. But what he directly gets cannot be an idea. Only by wrestling with the conditions of the problem at first hand, seeking and finding his own way out, does he think. (Democracy and Education 1916, p. 159-60)

Those of you who are Jane Austen fans will recognize her version of the same remark, from *Pride and Prejudice*, in the mouth of the witty (and prejudiced) Elizabeth Bennet: "We all love to instruct, though we can only teach what is not worth knowing."

Both of these people are telling you that learning requires thinking, not simple ingestion. Dewey was a radical and thought that this rule applied even to things like learning how to count and learning multiplication tables. (He did not mean to disparage all rote learning; sometimes we

want to learn relatively disconnected facts, as I shall note below.) But irrespective of its applicability to nursery and grade school, Dewey's statement is absolutely applicable to whatever you read in a theory course. You cannot be "told" what is in the texts we shall read. What you get, if you are "told," is just dead facts. It is easy to know that on p. 51 of Suicide Durkheim says "The suicide rate is therefore a factual order, unified and definite, as is shown by both its permanence and its variability." You just have to open the book to see that, and it is safe to assume that the sentence has been underlined in 75% of the physical copies of the book that exist. But the real question is: what did Durkheim think he was saying when he wrote that sentence?

He wrote the whole rest of the book to try to make the reader understand what he meant by that sentence. So if you have only five minutes to spend on the whole book, and by some wonderful happenstance you do find this sentence (you bought a used copy and found the sentence underlined and starred) and recognize that it is the single central sentence in the entire work, you still don't know anything about Durkheim. You just know that "he said the social suicide rate is a social fact." That sentence is not a living idea for you; it's just a dead fact.

But writers have ideas, not facts. They struggle to put those ideas into words that can be printed. They say their ideas a dozen different ways because none of them is quite right. They write long books because they think they can tie down the ideas by specifying more about them. But all that extra writing simply makes the rich ambiguity of the ideas even more evident. Thus, it is not the case that there are, somewhere hidden in the texts that you will read this quarter, magic sentences that, if only you can find them, will be "the only things you really need to know to understand Durkheim (Weber, etc.)." It is not the case that the texts you will read are made up of a) good material which should be underlined, highlighted, or downloaded and b) verbose rubbish which should be skipped or ignored. If you want to know the ideas of these writers, you must read them enough to begin to re-create, in your own mind, the debates and issues that they faced and you need to begin to be able to generate, within yourself, the answers that they generated. Then you will understand what Durkheim meant by saying the suicide rate was a social fact, and you will be able to talk at length about Durkheim, because you have learned - that is, remade - his ideas for yourself. You will be able, as the saying goes, to "channel Durkheim."

This argument applies to lectures as well, of course. You will not "get" ideas from me. You will hear a bunch of facts from me. That's not because I don't try to *say* my ideas, but because you can't *hear* them as ideas. You will be able to hear my own wrestling, for the nth time, with these texts that I know quite well, trying to recreate in myself in new and better ways the ideas that motivated these texts. So you will see and hear me "having ideas." But you won't get those ideas from me. You just get facts - about what my having ideas looks like. Ideas come from within you, from thinking about the lectures and the issues they confront.

Indeed, the example of lecturing provides another way to think about the difference (in Dewey's terms) between "getting facts" and "having ideas." Let's think about three situations: 1) you listen to a lecture but take no notes, 2) you listen to a lecture and take notes, 3) you hear someone speak using a set of PowerPoint slides. It is obvious to any of us that the first of these is much more intellectual work and that it results, actually, in much more retention.

Indeed, most of us veg out most of the time during a PowerPoint presentation. If the slides are simply flat text, with no gradual revealing of content through real time, we simply read the whole thing quickly, then wait for the speaker to "get on with it." If the content is revealed a step at a time, we generally get irritated. (I think this is because the speaker is forcing us a) to move at a predetermined speed and b) making us switch back and forth between reading and listening.)

Similarly, when we are listening to a lecture and taking notes, we focus on "deciding what's important" and "getting things down." We don't actually think much about what is being said. As a result, my college lecture notes meant almost nothing to me within a year of my having taken them down. As summaries of facts, they were far less useful than any textbook would be, yet at the same time, they didn't actually capture the main arguments the lecturers wanted to make. I couldn't see the woods for the trees. That's why I insisted in 2009 that my students in the Social Change class *take no notes*; I wanted them to get the big picture, to think about what I was saying. (Actually, I lectured for 50 minutes, then gave them 10 minutes to take notes on what I had said.) And in fact, they did as well on the exam they took on the basis of such delayed note-

taking as they did on the final exam they took three days after I had handed out a precise abstract of my general theory of social change.

That is, when we listen to a lecture without taking notes, but knowing that we need to get the basic points and the argument, we listen *actively*. We listen with questions in our mind. We continually try to recapitulate the argument. As the phrase is, we "pay attention." This means - quite simply - that we think. Actually, this whole argument is probably completely obvious to you. You already know that an interesting class takes a lot of effort and concentration but passes quickly, because you feel that you are "in it." A boring one takes minimal effort, leaves your mind wandering, and takes forever. That's because you're outside it, feeling that it's not worth concentrating on.

Let's talk, then, about how this same kind of distinction works in reading. Reading is a process by which we take in a bunch of words and sentences, masticate them in our minds, and digest them into ideas, which may or may not be close to the ideas of the author. The test of that reading is not whether we can exactly replicate the text; that's just memorization. The test is rather whether we can rethink the text, restating it in our own words. (That, for example, is why creating your own abstract of a text is a better way of studying than underlining or copying.)

Section 2 - Reading Preliminaries

Let's start with the basics, first disposing of "reading" as finding bullet points. Nothing you will contact in this course can be "read" by simply memorizing a list of bullet points. A list is not an argument. More broadly, no thought worth having can be expressed as a list of items without any logical connection between them. There are, to be sure, places in serious arguments where lists can be used. For example, there can be no logical connection between the axioms at the foundation of an algebra. The axiom of associativity does not come "before" or "after" commutativity; the whole point of axioms is that they are disconnected from themselves and everything else. But in general, simple lists are extremely rare in serious reflective arguments, no matter what the field. So get bullet points out of your head. Nothing you will read this quarter can be reduced to bullet points.

Similarly, as I already said, nothing in this course can be "read" simply by finding a subset of "key passages" which "summarize the whole book." It's true that you may want to create such a summary for yourself. But it won't work unless you *think* that summary and having thought it then state it in *your* words, which have *your* meanings (because most of the basic words used in sociological theory have notoriously ambiguous meaning - what does "social" mean, for example?)

It follows that reading is not a "search and find it" exercise. It is not the case that the true meaning of Dewey or Simmel is out there under a rock, and if only you find the right rock and turn it over, you're all set. In fact, none of the things worth learning at college is of this form, and, despite what the librarians say, no form of research can be organized around "search for known items." If you truly knew what you were looking for, you wouldn't have to search for it. The entire model of knowledge implicit in the internet and the digital utopia of the "information scientists" is wrong. The sooner you forget it the better.

So first, let us locate reading in the context of other skills necessary in education and scholarship. In a way, reading is continuous with browsing and scanning, two other important skills. When contrasted with browsing and scanning, reading seems simply to mean going slower and paying more attention. But actually there is a more substantive contrast between scanning and browsing on the one hand and reading on the other.

Scanning and browsing are basically associative techniques. In them, we analyse a text with a template or templates, what we might call "attractors." These are things that we already know and that serve to "attract" meanings in the text. If we already know who Hobbes is, for example, we will pay more attention to a sentence about him as we go through a text. By contrast, a sentence about (Hugo) Grotius probably won't set off any bells in most heads, even though Grotius was, in many eyes, as important a seventeenth century thinker as was Hobbes. But most of us haven't heard of Grotius, so we don't notice sentences about him.

In scanning and browsing, then, we are hoping to find ideas or facts or examples or citations that stick to our attractors, that associate with them. So scanning and browsing are dependent on a lot

of random knowledge about things (in order to have stuff to recognize in the texts we are scanning), and that's why memorization actually plays a crucial role in even advanced education. (For example, this is why we have [or should have] general exams for PhD students.)

But in reading we aim to find not single items, but arguments, descriptions, and other extended intellectual structures. We are seeking things that require thought and linear reasoning, not simple recognition. We find them not by associating them with attractors, but by mastering their syntax or pattern, trying again and again to recreate it inside ourselves. That requires a different type of attention.

Section 3 - Modes of Reading

Like scanning and browsing, reading can be done at many levels. But here the level is not determined by the density of the text in terms of expected return. Rather it is determined by the particular things we want from reading. Sometimes we want simply to follow a story. Sometimes we want to be stimulated to reverie. Sometimes we want to master the bare bones of argument. Sometimes we want to extract a particular bit or bits from a text. Each of these has its own strategy.

A. Narrative Reading

I start with narrative reading because it is the most familiar type of reading. It is reading "to get the story." Most of us started reading on narrative fiction, even if it was just Dick, Jane, and Spot (as it was for my generation - Spot was the dog, in case you wondered.) Your generation (this text was originally written for students about the age of my son, so the examples are based on his childhood) all started on *Goodnight, Moon* and *Where the Wild Things Are*. You graduated from those things to vampire novels and eventually to serious fiction like *Heart of Darkness*, *Anna Karenina*, and perhaps even *Middlemarch*.

No matter what kind it is, narrative fiction is written on the presupposition that you will read every word, in order, as if the story were being told out loud. Especially in nineteenth century fiction, this structure was exacerbated by the use of quite complex sentence structures, which almost cannot be read without subvocalization. You do in fact have to hear such a text in your

head in order to parse it. (Most contemporary novels are not like this - they are essentially just movie scripts, without much description and supporting text. By the standards of the 19th and early twentieth centuries, they are merely screenplays, not novels.)

But the main point of narrative reading is that you do it in order, and that it is absolutely dependent on your reading every word - as anyone who has missed a crucial clue in a mystery novel knows. And it is crucial to realize that most of us begin reading by reading in narrative mode.

It is crucial because reading of this kind is *almost never* necessary in social science texts in general. They are generally not organized as linear arguments in which every word must be read. They are often linear arguments, but they don't unfold as chronological structures or other temporal arrangements - rather they are structured around logical direction. They are not written with self-conscious elegance, but rather many of them follow rules for expository (as opposed to narrative) English prose that date from the late seventeenth century. They don't use long complex sentences, but mostly short sentences mixed with occasional long ones. They don't use clouds of ambiguous referents, but very clear referents and logical markers. They don't use bursts of dialogue or masses of description, but regular paragraphs with fairly obvious topic sentences (usually as opening sentences). They don't use a concealed plot comprising mysteries to be resolved but rather have clear logical structure. They do not use cliffhangers but rather have explicit section summaries, and so on.

Such texts are amenable to various forms of accelerated reading, which take advantage of their topic sentences and section summaries to skim much of the intervening text. In many books, there is a complete summary of the book's argument in the final chapter. For harried researchers, this is an irresistible invitation to ignore the whole of the book and read the conclusion only.

These are the general qualities of social scientific prose. But theory texts in particular can be hard to read this way. Some books of theory are written in an extremely logical, almost formulaic manner. Durkheim's *Suicide* is such a work, and, like many French books of its era, it includes a detailed table of contents that will enable you to master the overall structure of the book's

argument without actually "reading" a single page. On the other hand, Weber cannot be approached that way nor can John Dewey, despite his "summaries" at the end of the chapters. (They don't really summarize what he said, but usually say something parallel to what he said.)

With theory it is generally necessary to read in the next mode discussed, "Reading for Mastery of Argument." This is an extremely active form of reading, which will demand all of your focal attention. In sociological theory, you will have to read almost every word (as if you were reading fiction) but do so with an intensive concentration, often stopping, going back or looking forward, trying to create a pro tem argument summary, etc.

That said, there may be in a theory course some occasions for narrative reading. In particular, you read narratively when you are reading "in the background." In background reading you are not examining a particular argument or facts nor mastering the details of an occurrence or story. Rather you are orienting yourself to an area, getting used to the important names and concepts, immersing yourself in debates and problems. So this is what you are doing when you read Wikipedia entries on the people whose names come up in the theory we read, or when you glance through a biography of a theorist we read, or when you read some other theoretical work that might come up in class. You don't do this kind of reading to get an argument in exact detail, but rather to load up your medium term memory with the "browsing attractors" I discussed above. Your subconscious mind will retain from such narrative background reading a long list of things that, when you see them again, will set off a bell in your head: "I saw that somewhere and it's important for some reason." That you can't remember where you saw them is not particularly important. What is important is that you know you are supposed to pay attention to them. So you will know that you ought to pay attention now and take a few notes on them. And the next time, they will seem even more familiar. They will gradually start accreting notes, and it won't matter where you first heard about them. That's what background reading is for. It's a way of prepping for scanning, browsing, and closer mastery reading.

To be sure, you may want to occasionally take general notes on background reading. A timeline might be helpful - of a theorist's life, for example. Or a sketch biography, or a listing of some

major arguments. But the purpose of background reading is not to master things. It is to prime your browsing eyes with things to look for.

B. Reading for Mastery of Argument

This is a standard reading mode in social science in general. It is also the core reading mode for sociological theory. We apply this when we have a text whose core argument we must know, but whose peripheral details - examples, asides, minor corollaries - are unnecessary. There are several variables here that may influence one's choice of this reading strategy, and we have to think about that because even within the relatively short readings for this course, the amount of time required for Mastery Reading is such that you will probably have to pick and choose the core passages you wish to read this carefully.

Certain texts are more amenable to Mastery Reading than others. The crucial variables are: first, book or article length; second, greater or lesser density; third greater or lesser approximation to the highly organized prose mentioned in the discussion of narrative reading. Of these three, the third is the most important. A well-written and highly organized expository text can be mastery-read very quickly. How does one recognize such a text? At the book level, such texts are obvious because of their clear and helpful chapter structure, the presence of strong subdivisions within chapters, and, above all, the presence of clear summaries at the ends of chapters, sections, and subsections, and possibly even at the end of the book. (Thus, these things are *absolutely* the first things to look for when you confront a new book to read.)

Articles or chapters are more susceptible to mastery reading because there are a limited number of templates for such short texts: compare-and-contrast, case-analysis, quantitative- causal-analysis, adjudication of two theories, tell-the-story, and so on. Presumably, you know these templates well, and how to read them. (If you don't know them yet, make it a point to memorize them; they are quite formulaic, and provide obvious hints on "how they want to be read.") However, theory is seldom written in one of these templates, even at the article level.

The only general theory template is axiomatic argument, along the lines of geometry proofs. Very little sociological theory is written that way, and in fact less and less of it the closer one gets

to the present. Writers like Giddens are heavy on fluff, and writers like Foucault and even Bourdieu are often "impressionist," saying things in five different ways and leaving the reader to infer which interpretation of them actually makes sense of all five. If you go back to writers like Kant and Hobbes (to take two philosophers), you will find more or less axiomatic argument, but the burden in terms of specialized vocabulary is very, very high. You have to memorize the specific terms and how such authors use them before you can benefit from the axiomatic structure. It can in fact be difficult to see through the verbiage to the argument, an experience you will have (or perhaps have already had) in reading Marx.

So let's hope that the text you are reading is well written in the terms given earlier: clear divisions, logical organization, and constantly summarized arguments. In that case, Mastery Reading proceeds as follows.

First, you master the table of contents (for an article or chapter, this means the section structure, if any). Get familiar with it, read it four or five times. In fact, memorize it. Second, scan the index to find the dozen or so abstract terms that appear most often in the book. These will be the core terms of the author's argument. Either memorize these or become so familiar with them that you can recognize them quickly in the process of scanning pages. Write them down in a list. One of your basic tasks is to figure out how these words go together to make up the argument of the book.

Note that you cannot assume that you know what these words mean. They may mean something quite different to Durkheim or whomever ("corporation" in the standard Durkheim translation does not mean what you think it means; it means "guild.") That is, before you can figure out how these terms go together you have to figure out what they mean.

Third, check the last chapter (or final pages of an article) to see if there is a summary of the argument. Also check the ends of each chapter (section) for summaries of themselves. Note that some writers write bad summaries (Dewey!!); you have to watch out for that. If you find summaries, however, read them carefully, and note how the index terms you have already learned fit together within them. Try to recite the main argument to yourself, as if you were

telling somebody else what the argument is. Remember, you are not reading narratively. You are reading "from the top down." You should always be flipping pages, always moving back and forth, always forcing yourself to summarize how much you have gotten so far. If you catch yourself reading steadily ahead for five minutes - one damn word after another – STOP!! You are out of mode. You have gone to sleep.

Once you have mastered the layout, the terms, and the basic argument of a book (this will have taken about half an hour and feel like an immense amount of work), take a break. Then, scan the book for about fifteen minutes, looking for anything else to absorb, or add to your understanding of the argument. Then and only then, allow yourself ten or fifteen minutes to write a summary of the argument for yourself as a set of notes. Obviously, refer back to the table of contents, index, summaries, and text as necessary.

This entire process should take about an hour for a well-written 300 page book. By this process, you can, for example, probably master the first six chapters of my book on professions (these are the theoretical ones - your first scan will already have revealed that chapter one is introductory and chapters eight through ten are merely extended examples) in about an hour. Note that of this hour, you have spent as little as a quarter to a half actually "reading" sentences. The rest is all mastering the organization and finding what to read. You can be very sure that after an hour spent this way, you will know ten times as much about the book as you would if you read narratively for an hour. The latter process would put you about halfway through Chapter Two if you are a fast reader.

It is because you spend so much of this time flipping back and forth, by the way, that mastery reading is virtually *impossible* in the online environment. It simply doesn't turn the pages fast enough or enable you to scan large blocks of text easily. Rather, it enforces narrative reading, which is useful only in an extremely narrow range of research activities. This is why (for example) eighty to ninety percent of hits on the *American Journal of Sociology* website result in a print. Everyone knows instinctively that reading on a screen is not real reading.

Of course, in a theory course, you're going to spend more than an hour reading a text. But you should expect that at least half of time you devote to a text will not be spent "reading straight ahead" (and underlining or doing other soporific strategies for avoiding the work of reading). It will be spent flipping here and there, reading passages, rereading passages, working out little summaries, correcting those summaries, flipping some more, rereading a third time. If you are not doing this all the time, you aren't actually doing the reading for the course. You're just spectating. Education is not a spectator sport. It is a participation sport.

Often when you are in the mastery mode, you will not need to master a whole book. Rather, you need to extract some part of it and master that. I shall call this partial mastery reading. This is the most common mode of reading in the social sciences. Most of the time, when we read a book or article we want to know about some part of it; we want to know not "What Weber said" but "what Weber said about the motivations of Protestants." We want to know not "what Dewey said" but "what Dewey thinks are the sources of the public's problems." In these cases we do not want or need to master the whole of the book or article. We want something very specific, and we need understand only what is necessary to answer our particular questions.

Thus the most important requisite for research reading for partial mastery *is to have a very well-specified question*. That is, the most important thing comes from you, not from the text. Reading without questions always settles back into narrative reading, and narrative reading always fails as a mode of reading social science except history. (It actually fails for history most of the time.) The majority of reading you do as a social scientist is partial mastery reading and the majority of it is therefore very hard work. If you do not have to rest from reading because of sheer exhaustion, about every half hour, you are not working hard enough at reading.

The good news about reading theory is that there is a set of more or less *fixed* questions that you can pose ahead of time. Every serious social theory has to answer them. You have gotten well on towards mastery of a theory when you know the basic framework of these answers in a particular text and can put them together to make a serious replica of the argument. Note that I did not say that you have mastery when you can *recite* these answers. You don't. You have mastery when you can *deploy* these answers. That is, you understand Durkheim not when you can recite short

versions of his answers to the following questions but when you can take the theoretical arguments from the book *Suicide* and make up a pseudo-Durkheimian argument about cult membership. (That is, you understand Durkheim when you can *channel* him.)

In short, there is a master list of basic questions that you can use as template/questions for any theory text. Note that there could be many versions of this list. But they will all circle around these issues one way or another. In order to capture these questions as ideas rather than as simple facts, I'm going to say each one several different ways. You will need to put them together in your head and get a sense of that the idea is behind the simple statement that is each question. Note that even though these questions are "separate," some authors won't regard them as distinguishable. In the last analysis, for example, Dewey doesn't really believe the person and society can be distinguished - questions 1 and 2 are the same for pragmatist social theory.

B.1: List of generic questions for theory texts

1. What is the author's idea of the PERSON? Does he believe in "independent individuals?" What is the concept of human nature (is there one)? What are the crucial attributes of people?
2. What is the author's concept of SOCIETY? Is it "emergent?" Does it have "levels?" How is society mainly organized (groups? institutions? networks? do they overlap or are they exclusive?)
3. What about POWER and CONFLICT? How are they defined? Who or what exercises or suffers power? Who gets in conflict? Are power and conflict central or peripheral in the theory? Why?
4. What of TIME and PROCESS? Is the theory "historical"? Do narrative and contingency matter? If not, how does history work?
5. What CAUSES things in the theory? Does cause exist at all? How does it work, if present? What kinds of "causes" are there? Are things determined? By what? under what conditions?
6. What about PURPOSE, INTENTION, MORALITY? Are these discussed? What's the definition of rationality? Who has it? When? How is the concept of "oughtness" treated? Is there an implicit or explicit politics in the theory? How does the author imagine "purposes" in action?

7. How does the theory think about human DIFFERENCES? What kinds of differences matter? How are they created? How do they change? How do they interact? Are they central in the theory?
8. What are the INSTITUTIONS of social life? How does the theory approach things like family, religion, politics, markets, and other complexes of organized social life? How do such things change? Which ones are more important? Why?
9. How do SYMBOLS work in the theory? What does it say about language, mathematics, visual representations, memory? How are these related to other parts of the social process? Is the theory reflexive (does it in any way apply to itself)?

With a general set of questions like this, you are ready to read any kind of social theory.

And indeed, individual questions from this list can serve you for other kinds of reading. The central fact is that you cannot read for mastery without template questions. Without such questions, the whole of the text seems equally important. It's like going on a tourist trip without a guidebook. But here, the guidebook is not a list of things already found by other people. That would be dead facts, in Dewey's terms, and that's why Dewey would be opposed to modern tourism (See? I can channel Dewey.) What kind of a guidebook would Dewey think a tourist should carry? He would think a tourist should travel with a list of questions and do tourism by asking people "What kind of work do you do and why?" "What's the most important building in this town?" and so on. Imagine what an art museum would be like if, instead of walking around with earphones listening to lecturers telling them what they ought to see in this or that painting, people just asked each other what they saw in the paintings, in some kind of civil manner (a sort of Wikipedia of the museum on a given day - Dewey would have loved Wikipedia). You might not learn what the art historians think you should learn, but you would learn a whole ton of very interesting things, and if there were a few art history graduate students around (who weren't busy being professional but simply knowledgeable) the whole thing would be a much more alive experience than being told what to see. (This argument is a mess, but we can clarify it later - I'm just trying to make the idea-juices flow.)

B. 2 Back to Mastery Reading in general

In any case, once you have your template questions in mind you can tell yourself "This means that I do not need to know...." and recite to yourself the things you can and must ignore. (Again, if you are a good browser, the temptation to slow down is always great. Dewey often has exciting one-liners, and Simmel's examples are unbelievably clever. Don't succumb - keep reading for mastery!!) Then read the text very rapidly and mercilessly, insistently asking yourself, "Is what I am looking for on this page?" If it is not, then immediately go on. Do not pass "GO." Do not collect \$200. Do not look at this clever paragraph or that interesting citation. Just go on.

You should be able to "partially master" any article or book chapter, if you have a clear template question, in about 10 minutes. Again, this will be very hard work. If you don't think it is, then you are being lazy. By the way, *do not underline*. That takes time and is in fact just a way of shirking the intellectual task of mastering the text. Rather, find what you want and *write your own note about it* in a text file with the citation, after you have done the reading.

You will note that the recommendations for mastery reading always involve two stages: a) figure out what are the important things to discover from a text, and b) search for them and them alone. In general mastery reading, you use the table of contents and index, the headings and the abstract, to figure out what is crucial to understand. Then you read for those things and those things only. In partial mastery reading, you have your own reasons (perhaps you are simply rereading all books for this quarter, looking only for the comparative concepts of causality). These specify very clear questions and issues ahead of time. Then you read for those things and those things only. You are always reading *to find something in particular*, and you have always carefully delineated and imagined that something ahead of time.

The central mistake in scholarly reading is to employ narrative reading in situations where you should be applying mastery reading. Put in a slightly different way, never read a text without having specified ahead of time what you want to get out of it. Any other kind of reading is usually narrative reading and is appropriate only for background work (or fiction). As I have said several times, the exhaustion test is the right one. If you aren't literally tired out with the sheer work of focusing on a text, you aren't reading properly. You are just drifting along with the

narrative (of a text that probably is not a narrative text.). Effective scholarly reading is hard work.

C. Meditative Reading

In most of social science it is only occasionally that you want to read more slowly than everyday narrative reading. This is called meditative reading. With sociological theory, you read meditatively when you are looking within yourself for new theoretical ideas. A good exercise is to read a couple of favorite pages of some theorist over and over, just letting yourself meditate on each phrase. (We'll do some of this in class.) As a meditative reader, you read every word, slowly, and allow your mind free range to resonate with the text. You are attending to possible allusions, to interesting themes, sometimes even to the sounds of the words. You are likely to read a paragraph or two, then look at the wall and reflect for several minutes. Then perhaps you jot a few notes in a theory folder as ideas drift into your head: What does the author think about the relation of individual and society? Why is the author so worried about causality? Do I, myself, actually give the slightest damn about causality? If I don't and this author does, then which one of us is wrong and why?

Then you read some more. You are going to spend three or four minutes per page. Perhaps even more. You are not aiming to get through something; your aim in meditative reading is first to stimulate your own thinking and second to give that thinking time to happen. Your mind (and your body, in fact) must be relaxed if deep thinking is going to occur. The strategy is to let the text come apart into pieces in your mind and keep echoing and reechoing. Obviously such a strategy works only with very rich texts. Hence you will generally apply meditative reading only to important works of theory or to central passages within larger texts. For example, if you really want to understand Durkheim's book *Suicide*, you *must* read the first seven pages of Book Two this way. There is no more important text in all of Durkheim.

This is as good a place as any to remark that the belief that "I can multitask" is wrong. It is simply an excuse for being unable to concentrate on one thing. Until you are a real adept of reading, you cannot read effectively when there is any other form of intensive sensory input. This means you cannot read: a) when you can hear music, b) when any form of video input is in sight

(TV, movie, etc.), c) when you are interrupted by social interaction with others, d) when you have a computer nearby with open applications other than what you need for note taking (in fact, computers are so tempting that I would suggest you take your notes by hand if you find that you are being tempted to "just see what's happening on Facebook." It goes without saying that all notifications must be turned off. All of them. You cannot read while you are waiting for a phone call from your friend. In this university, as in most, the best place to read is in the library, in a quiet area, out of sight of activity. The stack desks in Regenstein are probably the best, although I remember going buggy in them when I was a student; they're too lonely. If you find that you can't function without some level of distraction, then force yourself to read very actively and intensively (in Mastery Mode) in ten-minute bursts. Then take a ten minute break. Ten minutes of intensive mastery reading is worth half an hour of distracted "multitasking."

But meditative reading cannot be done in intensive bursts, any more than real meditation can. You simply have to find a quiet place and allow yourself to think without distractions.

Section 4 - Theory and Context

If I were talking about the kind of reading applicable to primary documents, in real research, the next topic would be "doubt." That is because one main task in research reading is to try to second guess the text: does it have some special rhetorical purposes? some particular audience? a reason to be lying? Is it decisively shaped by the age or social position of the author, to the point where we may have to question even its factual assertions?

But we are not here concerned with primary documents, for which such questions would be central. Rather we are concerned with self-conscious attempts to conceive of society systematically. In reading the things that we regard as canonical theory texts, we simply make the decision to read "as if" comprehensive doubt were ruled out. Our task is then not so much to doubt that the author actually means what he says as to make sure that we understand what he thinks he is saying. For the most part, this means being very sure about a) whom he takes to be his audience and b) any specific elements of the context that are necessary to understand his meanings. This does not mean the same thing as a fundamental "doubt" of the text, in which case

we are setting ourselves "outside" the text and it becomes for us merely a fact to be explained. It means "thinking about context." These are not the same thing.

Whether or not to read a text "in context" is a problem especially important with theory. You should by now be familiar with the debate between reading in context and reading out of context. Under the latter, you don't learn much about an author (beyond gender, which you know automatically because of your knowledge of onomastics, which is pretty much absolute in your native language, and gets pretty good for most others as well). That is, you don't learn where an author lived, what social class she was from, what positions he held, what her marriage was like, etc. Similarly, you don't learn much (unless you already know it) about the historical events, popular controversies, long trends, and so on that shaped the book.

Willy-nilly, you start out (in school) reading texts in this decontextualized way, simply because you don't know much already and you don't have the time to learn it if you are actually going to read texts. Then as you get older, you begin to contact contextualized reading, and you have to start to choose, for any particular text, how you are going to read it. Some teachers in the core at Chicago emphasize context, for example, while others militantly avoid teaching anything about context, focusing on the texts alone. This varies in historical time as well as across the life course. Some epochs are dominated by "external criticism" - literary criticism based on author characteristics and other contextual matters. In such periods, teachers feed students a load of context to enable them to "understand what the text is really saying." Presumably that's what happened with most of you in your education so far, since this is a highly externalist epoch, attributing much of an author's meaning to gender, class, and other things. But in other times - for example, when I went to school and learned detailed reading under the "new criticism" - we weren't taught anything whatever about the class position or marital status of Charles Dickens or Ralph Ellison or George Eliot or whomever. (Note that George Eliot is an example of how it's easy to get gender wrong - George Eliot's real name was Marian Evans.)

As you grow older, if you retain any allegiance to education, you begin to read more and more in context. It's inevitable. You learn more and more contextual facts. You begin to understand how

dependent your own views are on your life situation. A progression towards reading in context is inevitable.

Yet any time you sit down to read, you are still going to make a decision about how much context you want to know. You make this decision even if you don't think about the matter, for that is simply to opt for no context or for the default context that is "whatever I already know about this author and text."

When you read sociological theory, you are mainly interested in the internal architecture of the argument, not in the external qualities of the author. It is true that you could read theory merely for the purpose of "explaining" it. For example, you could read Marx and Weber with only the intent of showing how German they are, or how masculine they are, or how amateur they are, or whatever, or how migrant status (Marx) decisively shapes a writer.

But that is not the framework of theory reading in this course. It is our rule in this course to read these theorists while "bracketing" their external circumstances, interesting as these often are. ("Bracketing" is a formal term from phenomenology [a specific philosophical school] that means "knowing something perfectly well but doing your best to set it aside for the moment.") I will provide plenty of contextual material about the various writers, but not with the intent of explaining what they had to say. Rather, that contextual material will relate in some cases to understanding the texts better (because some of it is presupposed) and in other cases to adding a kind of contrastive excitement to the texts (Weber's love life had a surprisingly strong effect on some of his writings – particularly the "Vocation" essays. I used to give Marx as an example, saying that his revolutionary writings contrast with his theatrically happy family life. But I recently discovered that the latter was a myth created by later communists, and his family life was far from happy. This example shows that you keep learning things throughout life!)

Section 5 - Particular Types of Materials. (a somewhat cranky section)

Some theory is better written than other theory. At heart, this sentence really means "some theory conforms better to [my or your] ideal of theory than does other theory." Personally, my own ideal for theory is argument that has an axiomatic structure underneath it, but that is written in clear

prose that deals effectively with the inevitable problems of axiomatic argument. By axiomatic argument, I mean argument that proceeds linearly along lines set out by classical logic, starting from primitives like definitions and axioms, and developing those things into more and more complex inferences and results. If you have done any branch of theoretical mathematics (e.g., geometry taught in terms of proofs) you will know what I mean.

The problem is that social theory in some ways is not amenable to axiomatic argument. Many of its arguments are inevitably circular: you can't have A without defining B, you can't have B without defining C and you can't have C without defining A. Therefore most social theory starts somewhere relatively arbitrary and builds up from there. Still, one hopes that it builds carefully, with attention to logic and definition, and, indeed, with a due recognition of its own circularity.

Another problem is that crucial terms in social theory cannot be defined. What is a "norm," for example? Or what are we assuming when we use the word "structure?" Even worse, important aspects of theory creep in without being defined at all. "Structure," for example, tends to mean "something that is fixed at a given time," even though we could use the term to refer merely to any form of constraint existing at a given point in time, even if that form were continually changing. (Example: the "structure" of your family constrains you a lot at any given time, but it changes steadily over time as new kids arrive, divorces happen, etc.) So there's an immense amount of dangerous baggage in the very words we use. Some words are so overused (e.g., "culture") that it is quite difficult to use them effectively at all.

All of these things mean that the axiomatic ideal, while useful as an underlying structure, cannot be enforced on sociological theory to any large extent. Social theory that is actually done axiomatically is - to be blunt - pretty silly. A good theory writer, in my view, uses the subtlety and complexity of prose to help unpack and resettle the complexities inevitable in writing about social life. Thus the axiomatic ideal relaxes into writing that is structured, logical, and clear, but at the same time rich and nuanced. Of course, those words (logical, nuanced, etc.) mean different things to different people. So again, one must be careful.

That said, let me offer some hints about how to read work that is not written clearly in terms of the prose ideals discussed earlier: clear language, occasional summaries, careful sub-headings, strong underlying logic, and so on. There are varieties of such material, and different reading strategies are appropriate for them.

The most obvious source of variety is nationality. Prose aesthetics, and indeed the aesthetics of theory itself, vary considerably by the nation of the writer.

Modern French theoretical prose is almost impossible to read for mastery. It is written in a highly poetic style, almost impressionistic in nature, that states and restates, that uses appositives as logical connections, that has an incantatory quality best read quickly, without attention to logic and detailed argument (of which there often is surprisingly little) although what there is..... You get the point - that's a typical French theory sentence: long, complicated, list-y, but musical and rhythmic. Such prose can be very beautiful and quite stimulating and can be very useful for meditative reading. (Foucault is the classic example. Read axiomatically, Foucault is nonsense from one end to the other. Read as meditation, it is quite powerful!)

The basic drill with French theoretical prose - if you can manage it - is to read narratively but very fast. That is, just go straight ahead through the prose without really trying to figure it out as you go along. It's like looking for something very faint on the horizon; you glance quickly past it again and again, hoping to catch it with your peripheral vision. Gradually, these rapid readings will give you some basic terms and begin to suggest what the author is trying to say.

But with many modern French theory writers, you can't be sure, in the last analysis, whether the argument is actually there in the text or you the reader are putting the argument into the text. And yes, I am talking about Foucault and Bourdieu here. Foucault's work is beautifully written (he is one of the masters of French prose in the 20th century) but often historically wrong and usually without any logically defensible argument. Bourdieu is less beautifully written, but his arguments are more followable. Both of them share with Durkheim the habit of assuming from the beginning what they set out to prove.

German theoretical prose has the somewhat different problem that it includes lots of specialized terminology drawn from the heritage of German philosophy, particularly the high German idealism of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. It generally can't be read with much profit unless you already know a good bit of Kant, Hegel, and their kind. You have the sense that you are overhearing a conversation among physicists, who are busy explaining in impenetrable language something simple like why water flows downhill.

I have no real advice on how to read classical German theoretical prose. But certainly one begins by getting a pretty clear (memorize, if necessary) sense of the basic vocabularies and arguments of Kant and Hegel. These are words like: critique, reason, understanding, knowledge, dialectic, antithesis, transcendental, and so on. It's useful (actually, necessary) to read something authoritative like the *Encyclopedia of Philosophy* on the basic arguments of Kant on knowledge (*Pure Reason*) and morality (*Practical Reason, Metaphysics of Morals*) and of Hegel on Ideas (*Phenomenology of Spirit*) and on history (*Philosophy of History*). Do not by any means attempt these works yourself unless you have a whole quarter in which to do it. It's not that the ideas are transcendently (ha ha) difficult: it's just that the vocabulary, the necessary knowledge-of-the-tradition, and the often heroic assumptions require constant attention.

You will note that translations often have the German word following the translated word – that's a sign that German is making a distinction (usually a controversial one) between things that are all packed into a single English word. "Knowledge" is the best example – *Wissen, Erkenntnis, Wissenschaft, Verstehen, Vernunft, Kenntnisse*, and others could all under various circumstances be translated as "knowledge" (although the usual translations would be [I could be wrong] knowledge, recognition, science, understanding, reason, and knowledge). Each one of these words has a centuries-old debate about its meaning. And don't get me started on the tendency of the Germans to assume concepts into existence by coining giant nouns of the form "the nevertheless-unusual-preemptive-but-contingent-determination-of-life-being."

As you can tell, the prose ethic that I myself prefer - subtle prose stretched over a framework of argument that is clear and almost axiomatic - is that of English writers in the early and mid-twentieth century. In fact, it has been the ideal of English prose since the late seventeenth century

when John Dryden established it. It is true that English writing went on a kind of binge-eating spree in the nineteenth century. Some of the Victorian essayists are simply unreadable: longwinded, flabby, almost obscurantist. This is why we don't read Herbert Spencer any more. But clarity returned as an ideal in the twentieth century - particularly in academic prose - until, unfortunately, the baleful French influence began with the structuralists, then Foucault and, to a lesser extent, Bourdieu. It's beautiful to read this French stuff, but you have no idea, when it's all over, what you've just read.

Finally, a couple of words may be useful about current academic writing in the US. As for humanistic and historical writing, pre-1980 material is often highly focused and Drydenian. If you want to read a biography of some philosopher or historical figure, for example, find one from before 1980. Such a book will give you the basic details without the vacuous persiflage that conveys the airy theories of the more recent biographers. Most current work in literary studies, particularly, has been much influenced by continental philosophy and by the obscure prose in which it is written. Moreover, the typical modern literary piece is more interested to enact or exemplify an argument than to set it forth in careful detail. There is a high premium on allusiveness, wordplay, and canonical references to canons that you as reader are unlikely to know.

More generally, if you want a quick and reliable summary of a historical period or a person or school of thought, you want to find something published between about 1950 and 1975, written by somebody who was a faculty member at one of the world-famous universities of the UK or the US. These were books produced during the great expansion period of modern universities, and they were essentially the written-down lecture courses of the best teachers of that system. They are usually wonderful – informative, entertaining, readable. By contrast, for a variety of reasons, academic work after 1980 is often pretty ill-informed about the background facts of the things discussed, and is caught up in specialization, politicization, and theory-mongering. It is simply not useful for beginning scholars trying to learn the basics.

As for badly written social science, there is a great deal of it, without the pretensions - or the style - of humanistic writing. Much of it is trying to be good exposition but simply failing.

Because of that, you will have trouble reading it as efficiently as you can read well-written material. By the way, do not let the fact that something was hard to read make you think it more important. It may just be badly written or just plain bad. Rather, the main strategy in reading poorly written material is to take an even more dramatically self-generated approach. Since the article or book itself is not well organized, you yourself have to provide the organization and fill it in.

You begin by deciding on the closest template to what you are reading: is it a story? (perhaps put better, is it trying to be a story?) is it a case study? And adjudication of theories? Once you have decided on which of these it is, imagine the pieces necessary for a good version of that template, and scan the article to find them. Find as many of them as you can, and build in your mind a version of the article/book as it should have been written. Do not allow yourself any more time than you would have for a well-written work. Chances are that the weak writing is a sign of careless thinking and that there isn't anything wonderful to find no matter how long you work with it.

Section 6 - Conclusion

Reading is not a simple business. Choose your mode carefully. Work hard at reading. Take good notes on your thoughts (you will not remember them.)